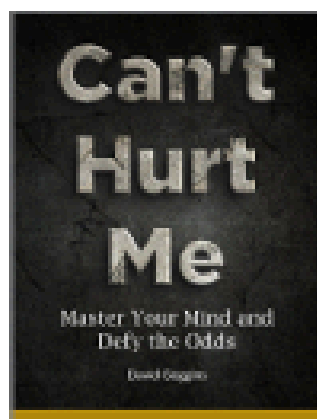




CAN'T HURT ME

Master Your Mind and Defy the Odds

David Goggins



Introduction



"Can't Hurt Me" is a memoir by David Goggins—a retired Navy SEAL, a Guinness world record holder, and an ultramarathon runner.

- This book chronicles his remarkable transformation as he overcame adversity, mastered his mind, and pushed past his limits. Specifically, Goggins shared how he overcame childhood physical abuse, racial prejudice, learning disabilities, went from being overweight to one of the fittest men in the world, and achieved endurance feats from 100-mile races to breaking the Guinness World Records for pull-ups.
- He also shared the turning points in his life, as well as the philosophies and strategies he used to overcome his challenges and redefine his limits.



The ideas are relevant for anyone who wishes to improve their physical and mental strength, and tap into their hidden potential. In this summary, we'll present the insights in 2 parts:

- Highlights of Goggins' transformative journey; and
- Strategies to explore and unlock your own potential.



Goggins' Journey: Breaking Barriers & Defying Limits

Goggins' personal transformation can be broadly classified into 3 phases: his early life, military achievements, and endurance feats. In each phase, he endured extreme physical, mental, and emotional pain. Yet, each challenge helped him to transcend his physical, mental, and emotional boundaries.

KEY QUOTES

"The story you are about to read...will illuminate a proven path to self-mastery and empower you to face reality, hold yourself accountable, push past pain, learn to love what you fear, relish failure, live to your fullest potential, and find out who you really are."

"We all make habitual, selflimiting choices. It's as natural as a sunset and as fundamental as gravity."



Early Life: From Trauma to Determination



Born in Buffalo (New York) in 1975, David Goggins' early life was marked by violence, poverty, and prejudice.

- Goggins lived in a broken home, and lived in constant fear of his father's uncontrolled anger. From the young age of 6, he had to work at night, and endure frequent and brutal beatings by his father. Although his mother eventually escaped with him, the trauma left deep emotional scars in Goggins' young mind.
- In school, Goggins was the only African-American kid, making him a target for racial prejudice. He was called "nigger", received threats, was physically attacked, and had his belongings vandalized. Each day was a battle for survival.
- He also struggled with dyslexia, attention deficit disorder (ADD), and toxic stress from the abuse at home and racism in school. These learning disabilities made it hard for him to concentrate, read and write. He even stuttered when he was stressed.
- Goggins felt angry and helpless with his lot in life. He started cheating to get by in school, unknowingly choosing the path of least resistance.



Then one day, he learned about Scott Gearen, a pararescueman who miraculously survived a catastrophic fall, and it gave him hope that anything was possible. Spurred by his new dream to

KEY QUOTES

"Prejudice is everywhere...if you are the only in any given situation, it's on you to decide how you're going to handle it because you can't make it go away."

"When you're driven, whatever is in front of you, whether it's racism, sexism, injuries, divorce, depression, obesity, tragedy, or poverty, becomes fuel for your metamorphosis."

join the Air Force as a pararescueman, he took steps to shape up mentally and physically.

- Goggins studied diligently for the ASVAB entrance exam, putting in extra effort to overcome his learning disabilities and passing the exam on his 3rd attempted. He also transformed his physique to meet the stringent Air Force standards.
- During pararescue training, Goggins started out strong. However, he floundered during Water Confidence Training because of his deep fear of underwater submersion. When he was diagnosed with a medical condition, the sickle cell trait, he took the chance to opt out of pararescue. He shifted to the Air Force Tactical Air Control Party (TACP), where he helped to coordinate precision air strikes and battlefield intelligence. This was a meaningful role, but Goggins had lost his drive and confidence because he knew he had given up on his dream.
- After he left the Air Force, Goggins fell into a dark place mentally and physically. He felt lost and aimless, stopped working out, started binge-eating, and gained so much weight that he reached 300 pounds and became pre-diabetic.



One night, Goggins saw a documentary about the Navy SEALs, and it sparked something in him. He badly wanted to have the SEALs' discipline and physical-mental toughness. But, he knew he was unqualified to even get admitted to SEALs training. Standing in his bathroom, he faced his "accountability mirror" for the first time.

- He was brutally honest with himself, acknowledging his unhealthy lifestyle and lack of direction. He resolved to change and used the mirror to hold himself accountable.
- Goggins wrote down his goals and what he needed to change, and placed the sticky notes on the mirror. Each day, he'd look at himself and the notes to remind himself of what he must do to achieve his goals. This became one of his foundational practices for self-development and success.

KEY QUOTES

"Only when you identify and accept your weaknesses will you finally stop running from your past. Then those incidents can be used more efficiently as fuel to become better and grow stronger."



Military Achievements: Honing the Body and Mind



To become a Navy SEAL, Goggins had to get in shape and complete the notoriously brutal BUD/S (Basic Underwater Demolition SEAL) training.

- To qualify for training, he had to lose 106 pounds in 3 months and pass the entrance exam. So, he adopted a rigorous routine: he woke up daily at 5am, spent 2 hours on the stationary bike ride, followed by a 2-hour swim, a gym session, and another 2 hours on the bike. If he missed just 1 pull-up, he'd force himself to redo an entire set of 250 pull-ups. To overcome his aquaphobia, he trained underwater, swam for miles, took a dip in freezing ponds, then ran in wet clothes—all during winter. Every spare moment was spent studying for his exam.
- BUD/S training culminates in Hell Week, where trainees must go through 5.5 days of continuous training (e.g. run 200 miles, do >1,000 push-ups daily, and conquer freezing waters) with only 4 hours' sleep. The average dropout rate is above 80% and Goggins had to endure Hell Week not just once but 3 times.
 - (i) The first time, he contracted double pneumonia and was vomiting blood during training. The second time, he fractured his kneecap but kept going regardless. Both times, he was forced to stop, recover, and start the ordeal all over again. Along the way, he confronted his inner demons, and developed various strategies to build his mental toughness. He learned to stop blaming others, and finally came to terms with his past trauma. He also started to see his pains and struggles as tools to make himself stronger and harder.
 - (ii) On his 3rd attempt, he successfully completed the BUD/S training to become the 36th African American in the history of the U.S. Navy SEAL.



Goggins didn't stop at becoming a SEAL; he sought to keep learning from other elite military units.

KEY QUOTES

"Everything in life is a mind game!"

"Know why you're in the fight to stay in the fight!"

"To develop an armored mind—a mindset so calloused and hard that it becomes bulletproof— you need to go to the source of all your fears and insecurities."

- For example, he earned the prestigious Ranger Tab from the Army Ranger School. This further stretched his physical and mental limits, and honed his ability to lead under extreme conditions.
- However, Goggins' single-minded pursuit of excellence started to isolate him from his peers, and he became overly arrogant and confrontational at one point. He only realized this after he was rejected by both the Navy's elite DEVGRU and the Army's Delta Force. After some self-reflection, he returned to the SEALs with a renewed commitment to become the best-possible instructor to nurture the next generation of SEALs.
- Goggins simultaneously started to participate in ultra-marathons (more details below). He also became a recruiter for the Navy, traveling around the country to share his story, and to inspire people to challenge themselves and explore new possibilities. He developed his own unique style as a speaker, e.g. running 50 miles to an event, doing pull-ups on stage while speaking, or inviting students to train with him.



Endurance Feats: Pushing Beyond Limits



Goggins' entered the world of extreme endurance sports to further push his boundaries and explore the potential of the human spirit. He saw every challenge as a chance to conquer his inner demons and transcend his personal limits.



He decided to run the world's toughest ultramarathon, Badwater 135, to raise money for the Special Operations Warrior Foundation (which supports the families of fallen special ops personnel). Although he had no prior experience, he went into a series of 100-mile races, including the San Diego One Day, The Las Vegas Marathon and The Hurt 100.

- Initially, he was severely under-prepared and finished the 100- mile runs through sheer perseverance. With each race, he learned something new, and progressively developed new strategies such as the "Cookie Jar" and splitting big goals into smaller parts.

KEY QUOTES

"When it comes to mindset, it doesn't matter where other people's attention lies. I had my own uncommon standards to live up to."

"A true leader stays exhausted, abhors arrogance, and never looks down on the weakest link."

(i) His first ultramarathon was the San Diego One Day, where he had to finish 100 miles in 24 hours. He was so dehydrated and depleted that his blood thickened to sludge and he urinated blood. Upon completing the race, he collapsed on the brink of rhabdomyolysis—a life-threatening condition associated with kidney failure. He trained harder for the Hurt 100, but still struggled with nutrition and hydration issues.

(ii) Then came Badwater 135—a 135-mile race through the blazing heat of the Death Valley with a total elevation gain of >14,600 feet. This time, he researched extensively for the race, visiting Death Valley to assess the terrain, and trained in layers of clothing to simulate the Valley's heat. Despite this, he was severely dehydrated during the race, and had to push himself onward despite blistered feet, hallucinations, and the agonizing pain of muscle breakdown. He finished the race in 5th place.

- He also participated in Ironman triathlons to challenge himself with back-to-back segments of swimming, biking, and running.



Goggins' intense participation in endurance sports created extreme strains on his body, and he suffered from problems with his feet, knees, and back. He was also diagnosed with a hole in his heart and develop lumps in his neck and other parts of the body. He decided to shift from running to a new challenge—to break the Guinness World Record for pull-ups in 24 hours.

- Despite a less-than-ideal physique and being surrounded by naysayers, he persevered and succeeded on his third attempt.
 - (i) During his first try, he lacked a proper venue and nutrition plan, and stopped just halfway to his goal. He was more prepared for the second attempt, but still failed to meet his target after his palms started to blister, crack, and tear all the way to the nerve-endings.
 - (ii) To prepare for his third try, he examined his past failures, worked on all possible areas of improvements, surrounded himself with positive people, managed his inner dialogue, and focused on what he had to do to achieve his goals. He successfully completed 4030 pull-ups in just over 17 hours to break the record in 2013.

KEY QUOTES

"It's possible to transcend anything that doesn't kill you."

"The ticket to victory often comes down to bringing your very best when you feel your worst."

"Most wars are won or lost in our own heads, and when we're in a foxhole we usually aren't alone, and we need to be confident in the quality of the heart, mind, and dialogue of the person hunkered down with us."



Conquering health challenges. Goggins' physical feats are especially remarkable given various health challenges.

- He had suffered from asthma since childhood. And, after numerous ultramarathons and triathlons, he was diagnosed with atrial septal defect (a hole in the heart)—a defect that had been affecting him since birth, without his awareness. Imagine what more he could have achieved without those ailments.
- After 2 heart surgeries to close the atrial septal defect, Goggins found that the lump in his neck had doubled in size. This was diagnosed as a benign growth and he later removed it through a surgery. Throughout the process, Goggins didn't stop challenging himself, e.g. switching from running to pull-ups.
- At the age of 38, Goggins faced yet another health crisis. This time, his muscles became rigid, his pulse rate escalated rapidly, and his condition deteriorated over several days to the point he thought he was dying. Again, he refused to give up. He recalled the lumps on his neck and hips, and a previous advice from a physical trainer's advice about the importance of stretching. So, he started to do hours of intensive stretching each day and eventually restored his health. This regime not only saved his life but left him in better physical condition in his forties than in his youth.
- After recovering, he resumed extreme endurance sports to keep pushing his limits and resilience.



Goggins retired from the Navy as a Chief Petty Officer in 2015, but his journey of self-improvement didn't stop there. He took on a new challenge as a woodland firefighter and continued his journey of learning and growth.



Exploring and Unlocking Your Potential

In this section, we'll detail the philosophies, strategies and approaches you can adopt to build mental toughness and explore your personal potential.

KEY QUOTES

"We should never feel that our work is done. There is always more to do."



Philosophies, Strategies, and Action Steps



Journal and confront your challenges. Confront your past traumas, current difficulties, or ingrained insecurities, take control of your narrative, and convert hardships into fuel for transformation.

- Reflect on the difficulties and challenges you've encountered. What circumstances, events, or people have hindered your growth and success?
- Write down all your struggles and limitations in a journal. Be as specific and thorough as possible. Give shape to your pain so you can overcome it.



Face yourself in the Accountability Mirror daily. Have a brutal conversation with yourself in the mirror.

- What are your dreams, goals, and insecurities? What problems or shortcomings are you avoiding? If you're overweight, admit it. If your temper is affecting your relationships, acknowledge it. Don't find excuses or sugarcoat it.
- Break down your goals into achievable steps. Write each step on a separate Post-It note.
 - (i) Stick the 1st step on the mirror, then hold yourself accountable with the mirror at the end of each day. Once you've completed step 1, replace it with step 2 and repeat the process. For example, if your goal is to run a marathon, start with a smaller target like finishing your first 1km, then upgrade to 3km, 5km, 10km, and so on.
 - (ii) Celebrate each small step toward your ultimate goal.



Develop a "calloused mind". Just as our hands become calloused from hard work, our minds can be toughened through adversity. Each time you step outside your comfort zone or overcome a challenge, you're strengthening your mind.

- Embrace and seek out discomfort proactively. Write down all the things that are good for you, but make you uncomfortable. Choose one task and do it daily until it no longer seems painful, then move on to the next item.

KEY QUOTES

"In order to change you have to work through shit. Confront it and get real."

"The only way we can change is to be real with ourselves."

"It's okay to be cruel to yourself as long as you realize you're doing it to become better. We all need thicker skin to improve in life."

"Your entitled mind is dead weight. Cut it loose. Don't focus on what you think you deserve. Take aim on what you are willing to earn!"

- Progressively increase the level of difficulty of your tasks. Each time you push through your pain, you thicken your mental callouses. Gradually, you'll build a strong, positive, a strong and calloused mind that stays resilient during tough times.



"Taking souls" is an ideal strategy for competitive situations.

- To develop a tactical advantage, you must know who you're up against. Is it your boss, your teacher, or a difficult client? Understand your opponent, yourself, and your circumstances. Show your rivals that you're not affected by the things that give them pain or discomfort. For example, if you're playing basketball against a team known for its strong defense, you must study their defensive strategies, understand each player's strengths, weaknesses, and tendencies, then develop counter-strategies for different scenarios. You must also cultivate mental toughness to stay calm and focused when the game gets intense. During the game, you'd have taken your opponents' souls when they realize that their usual strategies don't work and they can't get into your head.
- The best way to take someone's soul is to use their negativity to drive yourself to excellence. Get the top score in a test, deliver an outstanding project, or smash your sales goals. Do whatever it takes to exceed all expectations, so they cannot help but notice and respect you.



Visualization and mental preparation help you to take control of the thoughts running through your mind.

- Picture yourself achieving a goal, including all the obstacles you must overcome to get there. You're essentially preparing for and rehearsing the solutions in your mind. Remember: visualization is not the same as day-dreaming, and it cannot replace hard work. You must still back it up with real action, consistent effort, and discipline.
- It's equally crucial to get clear on your purpose and motivation: Why are you doing this? What motivates you? What drives or sustains you? In moments of doubt and pain, your answers to these questions will decide if you persist or give up.



Fill your "Cookie Jar"—a metaphorical container that holds all your past victories and the obstacles you've overcome. During tough times, these cookies will motivate you and keep you focused on your strengths and abilities, instead of your pain and doubts.

KEY QUOTES

"Know the terrain, know yourself, and you'd better know your adversary in detail."

"Taking Souls is a ticket to finding your own reserve power and riding a second wind."

"We don't rise to the level of our expectations, we fall to the level of our training."

"It's not the external voice that will break you down. It's what you tell yourself that matters. The most important conversations you'll ever have are the ones you'll have with yourself."

- Open your journal and list down every achievement and obstacle that you've overcome, no matter how big or small. This could range from quitting a bad habit to achieving a goal. Some of Goggins' cookies include: losing 100 pounds in 3 months, overcoming his fear of water to graduate from SEALs training, and breaking the world pull-up record. What are yours?
- Take a moment to re-live the mental-emotional state that got you through each challenge, and the sense of accomplishment from each victory.
- Set ambitious goals for the future. Each time you encounter difficulties and feel like giving up, dip into your Cookie Jar and let your past successes fuel you. Remember your strength and resilience, and use that energy to propel yourself forward.



Push beyond the "40% Rule". Most people only reach 40% of their true capacity because they stay within their comfort zone. To access your 60% untapped potential, you must push through your pain threshold and master your mind through consistency and hard work.

- For example, an amateur boxer might be knocked out by a single punch to the face. But after 10 years of experience, he will develop a much higher pain tolerance and can keep fighting even after being hit several times. Likewise, you can train your mind to handle a higher load.
 - (i) Choose a measurable physical activity (e.g. running or pullups). Push yourself to the point where your mind is begging you to stop, then keep going for another 5-10%.
 - (ii) Keep doing this to increase your baseline. Before long, you'll find that what seemed impossible is now within reach.
- Shift your thoughts away from questions like "What am I doing here?" to "What am I capable of?" As you expand your physical and mental strength, you'll start performing better in all areas of life.



Compartmentalize your day to improve your focus and productivity. Multi-tasking dilutes your focus and results. To get the most from your day, structure your schedule into time-

KEY QUOTES

"I was the sum total of the obstacles I'd overcome."

"You'll feel pain, but if you accept it, endure it, and callous your mind, you'll reach a point where not even pain can hurt you."

"Self doubt is a natural reaction to any bold attempt to change your life for the better. You can't stop it from blooming in your brain, but you can neutralize it, and all the other external chatter by asking, What if."

blocks, then work on 1 thing at a time. You can set this up progressively over 3 weeks:

- In the first week, observe and document everything you do and the time it takes. Include all activities, such as work tasks, meetings, breaks, naps, errands, and even distractions. This is to establish your baseline and identify the time-wasters.
- In the second week, start to optimize your schedule. Break down your day into blocks of 15-30 minutes. Then, assign specific tasks or activities to each time-block. Eliminate distractions, do 1 thing at a time, and give each task your full attention. Also set aside time for meals, exercise, and rest.
- In the third week, evaluate and adjust your schedule. By now, you should see an increase in productivity. Review how you used your time the previous week, and keep identifying ways to improve time-usage. Progressively cut back on unproductive tasks to free up time for dreams and goals. Create some buffers for unexpected events.



Fortify yourself through failures. Analyze your failures thoroughly to learn from them and prepare yourself for future challenges.

- Use your journal to write about your recent and most painful failures. Do this by hand and be honest with yourself. For each setback:
 - (i) List down the positives;
 - (ii) Reflect on how the event has impacted your life and relationships;
 - (iii) List down everything that went wrong and what could have been done differently; and
 - (iv) Examine your thought processes during the preparation and execution stages: were there any negative or unhelpful mindsets?
- Schedule another attempt in your calendar. During your preparation and execution, use all the principles and tools above, e.g. the Accountability Mirror, the Cookie Jar, the 40% Rule, and the calloused mind. If you fail again, just repeat the steps above.

KEY QUOTES

"If you audit your life, skip the bullshit, and use backstops, you'll find time to do everything you need and want to do."

"In life, there is no gift as overlooked or inevitable as failure."

"The point is not to allow a setback to shatter our focus, or our detours to dictate our mindset. Always be ready to adjust, recalibrate, and stay after it to become better, somehow."



Surpass the elites. This philosophy is not for everyone. It's about pushing yourself to become the best of the best, to sustain growth even if you've reached the top, and never get complacent.

- Acknowledge your past achievements, then set them aside and start again from zero.
- Keep set newer and harder goals for yourself. If you're a marathon runner, try ultramarathons. If you're a software developer, explore artificial intelligence or quantum computing. If you break a hand and cannot play the guitar, try playing the piano with your other hand as you recover.
- Intentionally put obstacles in your path to push yourself. Join elite groups and aim to become the best in every group.
- Such a singular focus on growth will mean disrupting other areas of your life, and you'll often stand alone as an over-achiever. Accept this as the price of true greatness.



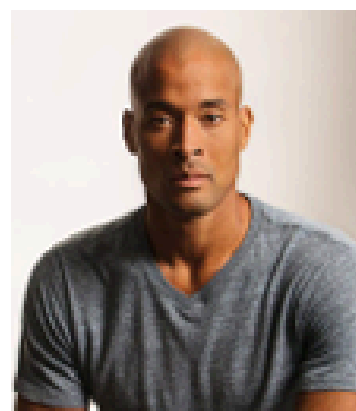
Other Details in the Book to Look out For

In the book, Goggins details his journey, insights, and transformation in vivid detail, helping the reader to understand his failures, triumphs, perspectives, and breakthroughs. He demonstrates that anyone—no matter your starting point—can change your life's trajectory through sheer will, determination, and an unwavering belief in yourself. For more information, please visit <https://davidgoggins.com/>.



About the Author

David Goggins (born 1975) is a renowned American ultramarathon runner, retired Navy SEAL, and former United States Air Force TACP member. He's also a public speaker and author. He has completed over 60 ultramarathons, triathlons, and ultratriathlons, setting new course records and regularly placing in the top five.



KEY QUOTES

"There's power in victory... but after our celebration we should dial it down, dream up new training regimens, new goals, and start at zero the very next day."

"I refused to compromise who I was to conform to their unwritten rules."